Britain’s Colonization of Australia

The Aborigines lived without influence from outsiders until the 17th century when the first European ships landed on the Australian coastline. When Captain James Cook arrived in 1770, the British colonized the country along the eastern coast. The colonies established were initially founded to contain convicts because the British prisons were already overflowing. On January 26, 1788, a fleet of 11 ships known as the First Fleet arrived in Australia with 1,500 people. Approximately half of these people were criminals who had been convicted by the British government. In 1868, the last penal ship arrived in Australia and is estimated to have had over 160,000 convicted men and women.

At the end of the 18th century, free settlers began to arrive in Australia but found life was more difficult than what they had imagined. Men who committed crimes were hanged or severely flogged for minor offences such as stealing. Women were frequently raped and abused since there were five times as many men compared to the number of women.

It was not just the European settlers who found themselves under threat. For the Aborigines, the newcomers brought with them illnesses and death from a variety of diseases they had no resistance to. A lot of aborigines lost their land and their lifestyle was changed forever.